archaeologists that the only significant human settlements in that part of the world were Iraqi.

The city was subject to an intensive archaeological expedition in 1920 and 1921, a project led by Rai Bahadur Daya Ram Sahni and the Archaeological Survey of India. From Sahni and his successors' excavations, historians learned that the Indus Valley people of Harappa and other contemporary cities along the Indus and Sarasvati were exceptionally well-structured. They built homes, temples, and public buildings of brick and arranged these in neat, even rows and squares. The largest Harappa building was found at the site of the ancient city Mohenjo-daro, home of a public work called the Great Bath. This building—along with every structure in each of these cities—was connected via underground ducts to a city-wide drainage system that rivaled the modern systems used by the archaeologists themselves.

Harappans enjoyed all the natural resources necessary to produce surplus food and promote trade and permanent communal living. Since both river systems flooded reliably twice a year, residents were able to sow and reap two harvests per year and provide for their families as well as keep food stockpiled. These simple people lived in family groups and cultivated wheat, barley, cotton, and hemp while often keeping several cows, sheep, and goats. It was the Neolithic Revolution: a defining period of south Asian history during which people shifted from traditional nomadic hunting and gathering methods and into an agrarian lifestyle. For those early Indians, the center of the revolution was the floodplains. Possibly the world's oldest cities lay within those one million square kilometers (386,000 square miles), characterized not only by carefully built brick buildings but miniature sculptures, artwork, religious texts, and commercial artifacts like personal seals used to identify trade products. Clay seals and tablets feature untranslatable writing and inscribed drawings of elephants, lions, and rhinoceros.

The Sarasvati people developed regular trade routes, methods of sturdy shipbuilding, and navigation so that they might visit the lands to the east and west, including Mesopotamia and Egypt. There, they brought their own gold, copper, timber, ivory, and cotton, and purchased bronze, tin, silver, and soapstone to bring back to India. Archaeologists have found many of these items in unnatural locations, such as bronze, not native to the Indus Valley—proving the link between neighboring groups and cultures.